



# INDIAN FOOTBALL GRAPPLING WITH A MIDFIELD CONUNDRUM

Foreign midfielders wield considerable influence for many teams in the Indian Super League, **while their Indian counterparts struggle** with a shortage of opportunities and less-than-ideal playing positions, adding to the challenges for national coach Igor Stimac.

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**D**uring the Indian Super League (ISL) knockout match between Odisha FC and Kerala Blasters in April this year, Ahmed Jahouh executed a pass few would dare to attempt at 1-1 in extra time.

The deep-lying midfielder of Odisha arrowed in a straight first-time no-look pass over the Blasters' defence and found Roy Krishna, whose well-timed run behind a flat-footed opposition backline allowed him to set up Isak Ralte for the match-winner.

Even at 35, Jahouh's mastery over the ball continues to leave many

spellbound. He can dictate the pace of play — deciding when to speed up proceedings or slow it down to provide control in possession — and when to switch play with his range of passing capabilities. **A midfielder like him can have a transformative effect on a football team**, as Odisha discovered by bringing the pass master from Mumbai City FC.